Ichigo Project Development Documentation

Version 2.1 · May 31, 2026

1. Executive Summary

Ichigo is a context-first feedback product. It lets a user share a post and make the response context explicit before other people reply. The central thesis is:

> **A post is not just content. It is content plus context.**

The current product should be understood as a late-alpha / closed-beta candidate for founders, builders, and a narrow slice of creators. It is not currently positioned as a broad social network or a public Twitter, Reddit, or LinkedIn substitute.

The long-term vision remains broader: a context-first social graph where people are rewarded for meeting the response context another person explicitly chose. The near-term strategy is narrower: prove that explicit response context creates better replies and stronger return behavior inside a selected closed beta.

2. Product Thesis

Conventional social media makes people guess the context behind a post. A person may want comfort, advice, encouragement, direct critique, or quiet listening, but the platform usually treats all replies as the same kind of interaction.

Ichigo makes that context visible. Every post carries a response mode that tells responders how the poster wants to be met.

Ichigo asks: What do you want to say, and how do you want people to meet you?

3. Current Positioning

For the current closed beta, Ichigo is for:

- founders making product, hiring, launch, or strategy decisions
- builders sharing progress, doubts, technical work, and project choices
- selected creators who need structured feedback on public work, drafts, or direction

Ichigo is not currently for:

- general social posting
- viral entertainment
- unbounded anonymous confession use

- mass public debate

4. Brand Promise

Ichigo helps people say what they need and receive what helps. The strongest brand line remains:

> **Choose how people meet you.**

This should guide the landing page, onboarding, closed-beta flyers, product copy, and invite messaging.

5. Response Modes

The current product supports these core modes:

- **Hype Me:** encouragement, celebration, and momentum.
- **Comfort Me:** warmth, reassurance, and emotional steadiness.
- **Advise Me:** clear suggestions, options, and next steps.
- **Soft Truth:** honesty delivered with care.
- **Challenge Me:** pressure, accountability, and sharper questions.
- **Just Listen:** acknowledgement without trying to fix the post.

These modes are not decorative labels. They are the interaction contract for the post, and replies are evaluated against that contract.

6. Current Application State

The current application includes:

- Next.js full-stack application with App Router routes and backend route handlers.
- Email/password auth and Google sign-in.
- SMTP-backed transactional email.
- Email verification through 6-digit codes.
- 30-minute verification code expiry.
- Invalidation of older verification codes when a new code is sent.
- Password reset, stronger password policy, session management, and session revocation.
- Onboarding before full app access.
- Feed, compose, thread, rooms, profile, activity, settings, and moderation routes.
- Block, mute, unmute, unblock, report, and comment deletion flows.
- Dismissible flash messages for important user actions.
- Responsive navigation and light/dark theme support.

7. First-Use Flow

The intended first-use flow is:

1. User creates an account.
2. Ichigo sends a 6-digit verification code.
3. User is sent directly to the verification-code screen.
4. User verifies email.
5. User completes onboarding.
6. User creates or replies to a mode-shaped post.

Users who are signed in but unverified should not be able to use core product surfaces until their email is verified. Users who are verified but not onboarded should be routed through onboarding before normal app access.

8. Reply Fit Checking

Ichigo includes a reply-fit layer that checks whether a response respects the ask attached to the post. The current system uses:

- heuristic mode-alignment scoring
- ask-aware checks for relevance and tone
- rewrite guidance for low-fit replies
- cooldown consequences for repeated low-alignment behavior
- optional Gemini second-pass analysis for manual Check fit and rewrite refinement

This system is strong enough for closed-beta learning, but it should still be treated as experimental. Beta testing must measure whether it improves reply quality without frustrating responders.

9. Trust And Moderation

The current trust layer includes:

- reporting
- flagged reply handling
- moderation routes
- block and mute relationships
- reply-quality enforcement
- verification and onboarding gating

This is acceptable for a selected closed beta. It is not yet enough for broad public launch, where abuse pressure, spam, adversarial users, and scale would be materially higher.

10. Technical Architecture

The current local stack is:

- Next.js
- React
- TypeScript
- SQLite-backed local persistence
- SMTP email delivery
- Google OAuth
- optional Gemini API integration
- Vitest integration and domain tests

The next production infrastructure step is to move persistence to managed Postgres, deploy to a public environment, and add logging, monitoring, and backup/restore discipline.

11. Testing

The automated suite currently covers:

- security primitives
- repository and persistence flows
- response-mode alignment behavior
- HTTP auth and product flows
- verification, session, posting, and account behavior

Tests are a guardrail for closed-beta development, but they do not replace real user validation. The beta must measure behavior, not just feature completeness.

12. Closed Beta Plan

The recommended closed-beta shape is:

- start with 15 to 20 selected users
- expand toward 50 if the product remains stable
- prioritize founders, indie hackers, builders, technical creators, and product-minded students
- watch first-session comprehension, first-post creation, reply quality, and return behavior
- review reports, low-fit replies, mute/block usage, and support issues manually

13. Public Launch Blockers

Ichigo should not be treated as public-launch ready until these are addressed:

- managed production database
- observability, logging, and backups
- stronger anti-spam and abuse controls

- clear privacy, safety, and age-policy decisions
- more robust room-level moderation
- evidence of activation, reply quality, and retention from real users

14. Final Product Direction

> Ichigo should proceed as a focused closed-beta product for founders, builders, and selected creators.
>
> The long-term ambition can remain broader, but the product should not behave like a general social network until the closed beta proves that context-first feedback creates repeat usage.